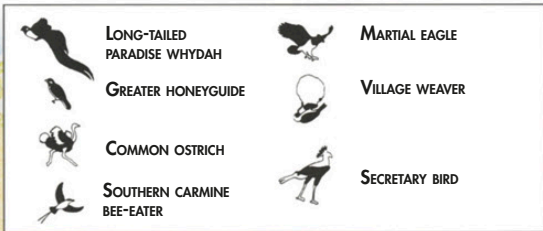




These village weavers' nests are at the tips of branches where predators such as snakes cannot reach them.



Village weaver

Village weavers live in flocks and build their nests together so that they are safer from attack. There may be as many as 100 nests in one tree. The male builds the nest from strips of grass which he weaves into a round ball. He starts by building a swing to perch on, then makes a ring shape and finally a round ball. To attract a female, a male hangs upside down from the nest, flicking his wings. If a female likes the nest, she lays her eggs there and raises her young by herself.

In the breeding season, the male long-tailed paradise whydah grows tail feathers up to 11 in (28 cm) long.

The weaver uses long, green grass stems to make the nest and loops and knots them together.

Village weaver
(*Ploceus cucullatus*)
Length: 7 in (17 cm)

Male village weavers may steal green grass from each other's nests.

D E S E R T

A F R I C A



Southern carmine bee-eaters live in colonies of hundreds. They dig burrows in the soil, often in sandy vertical banks.

The male holds his two short, wide tail feathers up above his long tail feathers during his display flights.

The female is a dull brown.

Long-tailed paradise whydah
(*Vidua paradisaea*)
Length: male: 1 ft 3 in (39 cm);
female: 5½ in (14 cm)

Long-tailed paradise whydah

To impress a female or ward off rivals, the male long-tailed paradise whydah shows off his remarkable tail. The whydah does not take care of its young. Instead, the female lays her eggs in the nests of melba finches. Young whydahs have the same colors inside their mouths as young finches and also copy their calls and behavior. This tricks the foster parents into feeding the whydah chicks as if they were their own.

Honeyguides have very thick skin to protect them against bee stings.

Greater honeyguide

The honeyguide can be taught to lead people or honey badgers to bees' nests. Once the "helper" opens up the nest, the birds eat the grubs and honey. The female lays her eggs in the nests of other birds—one egg in each nest. The young honeyguide injures or kills the other young with a hook on its bill.

Each bird has a special calling place where it often perches.

Greater honeyguide
(*Indicator indicator*)
Length: 8 in (20 cm)

The central tail feathers are up to 5 in (12 cm) long.

Southern carmine bee-eater
(*Merops nubicoides*)
Length: 1 ft 2½ in (37 cm)

Southern carmine bee-eater

The carmine bee-eater may perch on the back of an ostrich, stork, goat, or sheep, snatching up insects disturbed by its feet. It also gathers near grass fires where it eats up the insects trying to escape from the flames. The bee-eater specializes in eating stinging insects. To get rid of the sting, it holds the insect tightly in its bill and beats and rubs it against a perch. Then it swallows the insect whole.